

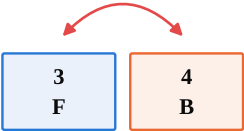
# How the assignment was made



position on the operating list →

Assignment is fully determined by list position: knowing position  $n$  tells you assignment  $n+1$ .

If the list order  
is changed after  
assignment ...



... the two patients exchange techniques.  
The order of an operating list is routinely adjusted for  
urgency, equipment and surgeon availability.

## The four safeguards of a randomised trial

- |                                                       |                                                                       |
|-------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ✗ Random sequence generation                          | alternation is systematic, not random                                 |
| ✗ Allocation concealment                              | a deterministic public rule can always be deciphered                  |
| ✗ Independently held, auditable sequence              | compliance with the rule cannot be demonstrated                       |
| ✓ <b>Blinding of participant and outcome assessor</b> | retained in full — but it protects measurement, not group composition |